

The Mauryan Empire - Learner-v2 Refreshed

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Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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The Mauryan Empire - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01 - Source method

Which source is securely contemporary with Ashoka and most directly reveals his public political-ethical voice?

- (A) Ashokan edicts
- (B) The final redacted Arthashastra
- (C) Megasthenes as quoted by Strabo alone
- (D) Ashokavadana legends

Answer: A - Ashokan edicts Explanation: The edicts are royal proclamations dated to Ashoka's reign.

Named evidence: Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions

Qualification: They reveal intention and self-presentation more securely than implementation.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 02 - Chronology

Which sequence is chronologically correct?

- (A) Bindusara -> Chandragupta -> Ashoka
- (B) Chandragupta -> Bindusara -> Ashoka
- (C) Chandragupta -> Ashoka -> Bindusara
- (D) Ashoka -> Chandragupta -> Bindusara

Answer: B - Chandragupta -> Bindusara -> Ashoka Explanation: The first three major Mauryas were Chandragupta, Bindusara and Ashoka.

Named evidence: Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction

Qualification: Exact accession years vary.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 03 - Arthashastra

What is the safest use of the Arthashastra in a Mauryan answer?

- (A) As the official Mauryan civil-service manual
- (B) As Megasthenes' lost eyewitness diary
- (C) As a theoretical statecraft text whose Mauryan application needs corroboration
- (D) As an Ashokan edict collection

Answer: C - As a theoretical statecraft text whose Mauryan application needs corroboration Explanation: Current scholarship treats the extant text as theoretical and substantially post-Mauryan/redacted.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate

Qualification: Earlier ideas within the text may predate its final composition.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 04 - Megasthenes

Why is Megasthenes described as evidence passing through a 'double filter'?

- (A) He wrote first in Brahmi and then translated himself into Greek
- (B) Two Mauryan kings censored every passage
- (C) The Indica survives in two complete manuscripts
- (D) His observations were interpreted by him and then selected by later Graeco-Roman writers

Answer: D - His observations were interpreted by him and then selected by later Graeco-Roman writers

Explanation: The original Indica is lost; fragments survive through later authors.

Named evidence: Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny

Qualification: Some observations are useful when independently corroborated.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 05 - Seleucus treaty

Which element belongs to the Chandragupta-Seleucus treaty tradition?

- (A) Transfer of 500 elephants to Seleucus
- (B) Ashoka's surrender of Kalinga
- (C) Bindusara's gift of the Sarnath capital
- (D) Seleucus becoming governor of Taxila

Answer: A - Transfer of 500 elephants to Seleucus
Explanation: Classical sources associate the settlement with territorial transfer and 500 elephants.

Named evidence: Graeco-Roman treaty tradition

Qualification: Exact date, marriage clause and territorial control remain debated.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 06 - Bindusara

Which statement about Bindusara is most defensible?

- (A) His Deccan conquest is documented by a contemporary victory inscription
- (B) He maintained Hellenistic diplomatic contacts, but the evidence for his conquests is thin
- (C) He founded the dynasty after Kalinga
- (D) He issued the complete pillar-edict series

Answer: B - He maintained Hellenistic diplomatic contacts, but the evidence for his conquests is thin

Explanation: Envoy traditions are firmer than detailed conquest narratives.

Named evidence: Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account

Qualification: Most evidence is later and fragmentary.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 07 - Imperial extent

What does an Ashokan edict find-spot most securely establish?

- (A) Uniform direct administration of the entire surrounding region
- (B) A permanent Mauryan garrison of known size
- (C) Imperial contact and an attempt at communication at or near that location
- (D) Absence of all local political institutions

Answer: C - Imperial contact and an attempt at communication at or near that location Explanation: Find-spots are evidence of message placement and authority claims.

Named evidence: Distribution of major/minor edicts

Qualification: Effective control must be tested with regional archaeology and context.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 08 - Provinces

Which pairing is correctly associated with a reconstructed Mauryan provincial centre?

- (A) Taxila - Kalinga province
- (B) Ujjayini - eastern Bengal province
- (C) Tosali - north-western province
- (D) Suvarnagiri - southern province

Answer: D - Suvarnagiri - southern province Explanation: Suvarnagiri is associated with the southern administrative network.

Named evidence: Ashokan inscriptional geography

Qualification: The four-province scheme is reconstructed, not a complete official list.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 09 - Officers

The 2025 official Set-A key places Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta primarily at which level?

- (A) District level
- (B) Central court only
- (C) Foreign embassy level
- (D) Village level

Answer: A - District level Explanation: The locally held official key marks district-level administration.

Named evidence: UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III

Qualification: Their precise relative ranks and functions remain debated.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 10 - Mahamattas

Which officer category was specially created by Ashoka in his thirteenth consecrated year?

- (A) Sannidhatas
- (B) Dhamma-mahamattas
- (C) Samahartas
- (D) Senapatis

Answer: B - Dhamma-mahamattas Explanation: Major Rock Edict V records the new dhamma cadre.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict V

Qualification: They were ethical-welfare officials, not merely Buddhist missionaries.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 11 - Rajuka

Which description best fits the rajuka under Ashoka?

- (A) A hereditary village priest only
- (B) The keeper of the royal treasury in the Arthashastra
- (C) A high field officer with land-measurement associations and later judicial, welfare and dhamma duties
- (D) A Greek ambassador to Pataliputra

Answer: C - A high field officer with land-measurement associations and later judicial, welfare and dhamma duties Explanation: The edicts expand rajuka responsibilities beyond a possible surveying origin.

Named evidence: Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV

Qualification: The derivation from rajju is suggestive, not conclusive.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 12 - Reporting

What is the central administrative claim of Rock Edict VI?

- (A) All land was owned by the king
- (B) The sangha elected provincial governors
- (C) Kalinga was restored to independence
- (D) Reporters should convey public affairs to the king at any time and place

Answer: D - Reporters should convey public affairs to the king at any time and place Explanation: The edict presents strenuous royal accessibility and rapid reporting.

Named evidence: Rock Edict VI

Qualification: It is a command/ideal, not proof of instantaneous empire-wide compliance.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 13 - Justice

Which evidence proves Ashoka did not abolish capital punishment?

- (A) Pillar Edict IV's three-day respite for condemned prisoners
- (B) Rock Edict XII on sectarian concord
- (C) The Bhabru recommendation of Buddhist texts
- (D) The Sarnath lion capital

Answer: A - Pillar Edict IV's three-day respite for condemned prisoners Explanation: A respite presupposes the continued death sentence.

Named evidence: Pillar Edict IV

Qualification: The edict simultaneously urges fairness and mercy.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 14 - Military

Which conclusion about Ashoka's post-Kalinga military policy is safest?

- (A) He dissolved every military unit immediately
- (B) He preferred dhamma-vijaya but retained coercive power and did not announce army disbandment
- (C) He returned Kalinga and ended taxation
- (D) He renounced all judicial punishment

Answer: B - He preferred dhamma-vijaya but retained coercive power and did not announce army disbandment Explanation: Rock Edict XIII combines anti-war remorse with a warning to forest peoples.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII

Qualification: The frequency of later coercive operations is unknown.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 15 - Revenue

Which statement about Mauryan land revenue is most accurate?

- (A) No agrarian tax existed after Kalinga
- (B) One-fourth was uniformly collected everywhere
- (C) Rates and actual collection varied across regions and sources
- (D) Every plot was legally owned by Ashoka

Answer: C - Rates and actual collection varied across regions and sources Explanation: Rummindei, classical notices and normative one-sixth claims differ.

Named evidence: Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms

Qualification: A concession at one village is not an empire-wide schedule.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 16 - Rummindei

What fiscal measure is recorded at Lumbini in the Rummindei inscription?

- (A) Appointment of Seleucus as governor
- (B) Creation of six army committees
- (C) Abolition of all taxes in Kalinga
- (D) Exemption from bali and reduction of bhaga to one-eighth

Answer: D - Exemption from bali and reduction of bhaga to one-eighth Explanation: The inscription links pilgrimage, commemoration and a local tax concession.

Named evidence: Rummindei pillar inscription

Qualification: The prior rate and precise meaning of bali need caution.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 17 - Irrigation

Which evidence connects Chandragupta's and Ashoka's administrations with the Sudarshana reservoir?

- (A) Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription
- (B) Major Rock Edict XII
- (C) The Kanaganahalli portrait label
- (D) Megasthenes' seven social groups

Answer: A - Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription Explanation: The later inscription credits Pushyagupta and Tushaspha in the reservoir's history.

Named evidence: Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman

Qualification: It is retrospective evidence written centuries later.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 18 - Economy debate

Which position best fits the evidence on Mauryan economic control?

- (A) A proven total command economy
- (B) Selective and regionally varied state intervention alongside local and private activity
- (C) A state with no taxation or regulation
- (D) An economy controlled exclusively by Buddhist monasteries

Answer: B - Selective and regionally varied state intervention alongside local and private activity Explanation: Inscriptions show partial interventions; archaeology shows multiple actors.

Named evidence: Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts

Qualification: Arthashastra monopolies are prescriptions, not an audited economy.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 19 - Coinage

Which caution applies to Mauryan punch-marked coins?

- (A) All were gold dinaras
- (B) They ended payments in kind
- (C) Symbols may have political or religious meaning, but ruler attribution is often speculative
- (D) Every symbol is a dated portrait of Ashoka

Answer: C - Symbols may have political or religious meaning, but ruler attribution is often speculative

Explanation: The motifs came from a broad early-historic cultural pool.

Named evidence: Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies

Qualification: Coin use and monetisation remained uneven.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 20 - Urban archaeology

Which archaeological pair most directly supports a large wooden fortified Pataliputra?

- (A) Maski and Brahmagiri
- (B) Dhauli and Jaugada
- (C) Sanchi and Bharhut
- (D) Kumrahar and Bulandibagh

Answer: D - Kumrahar and Bulandibagh **Explanation: Kumrahar has a pillared hall; Bulandibagh has wooden palisade remains.**

Named evidence: Excavations at ancient Patna

Qualification: The hall's exact function and stratigraphy remain debated.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 21 - Megasthenes society

Megasthenes' seven social groups are best understood as:

- (A) A Greek classificatory construction mixing occupations and administrative ranks
- (B) The official seven varnas of Mauryan law
- (C) An Ashokan census table
- (D) Seven Buddhist monastic grades

Answer: A - A Greek classificatory construction mixing occupations and administrative ranks **Explanation: They do not correspond to varna or jati.**

Named evidence: Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis

Qualification: Some notices still capture heredity/endogamy tendencies.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 22 - Slavery

Which evidence directly contradicts Megasthenes' claim that India had no slaves?

- (A) The Sarnath wheel
- (B) Ashoka's reference to dasas and bhatakas
- (C) The Seleucus treaty
- (D) The Kalsi elephant alone

Answer: B - Ashoka's reference to dasas and bhatakas Explanation: Rock edicts prescribe courteous conduct toward slaves and servants.

Named evidence: Rock Edicts IX/XI

Qualification: Terms cover varied forms of dependence and do not quantify prevalence.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 23 - Women

What can the Queen's Edict of Karuvaki most securely demonstrate?

- (A) Abolition of patriarchal norms
- (B) General equality of all Mauryan women
- (C) Elite female authority to make recorded pious gifts
- (D) Female control of the entire army

Answer: C - Elite female authority to make recorded pious gifts Explanation: The inscription records groves, gardens and alms-house gifts.

Named evidence: Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar

Qualification: An elite case cannot represent all women.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 24 - Religious plurality

Which fact most clearly disproves the claim that Ashoka established an exclusively Buddhist state religion?

- (A) His pilgrimage to Lumbini
- (B) His conquest of Kalinga
- (C) His use of Brahmi
- (D) His Barabar cave donations to Ajivikas and calls to honour all sects

Answer: D - His Barabar cave donations to Ajivikas and calls to honour all sects Explanation: Patronage and public policy were plural despite personal Buddhism.

Named evidence: Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII

Qualification: Plural patronage still operated under paternal monarchy.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 25 - Kalinga chronology

Major Rock Edict XIII dates the Kalinga conquest to:

- (A) After eight completed years from Ashoka's consecration
- (B) The final year of Bindusara
- (C) After Ashoka's death
- (D) Before Chandragupta's accession

Answer: A - After eight completed years from Ashoka's consecration Explanation: The war occurred in the ninth regnal year after abhisheka.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII

Qualification: The absolute BCE year depends on the reign chronology used.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 26 - Kalinga casualties

How should the Kalinga casualty numbers be used?

- (A) As figures from Megasthenes' Indica
- (B) As Ashoka's inscriptional claims, not independently audited statistics
- (C) As proof that Kalinga was uninhabited afterward
- (D) As modern census-certified totals

Answer: B - As Ashoka's inscriptional claims, not independently audited statistics Explanation: The figures are powerful direct royal testimony but not corroborated counts.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII

Qualification: Their rhetorical and commemorative context matters.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 27 - Separate edicts

Why are Dhauli and Jaugada especially important?

- (A) They contain the Sarnath lion capital
- (B) They are the only Kharoshthi sites
- (C) They preserve Separate Kalinga Edicts on post-conquest administration and confidence-building
- (D) They record Chandragupta's Seleucus treaty

Answer: C - They preserve Separate Kalinga Edicts on post-conquest administration and confidence-building Explanation: Their regional text replaces parts of the standard major-edict sequence.

Named evidence: Separate Rock Edicts I-II

Qualification: Policy orders do not prove complete implementation.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 28 - Dhamma

Which formulation best defines Ashoka's public dhamma?

- (A) The complete Buddhist monastic Vinaya
- (B) A modern secular constitution
- (C) A programme of compulsory conversion
- (D) An imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, focused on conduct, non-injury, welfare and concord

Answer: D - An imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, focused on conduct, non-injury, welfare and concord **Explanation: The edicts address everyday relations and multiple sects.**

Named evidence: Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts

Qualification: Dhamma remained paternal and tied to merit/heaven.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 29 - Religious concord

Major Rock Edict XII goes beyond passive tolerance by urging:

- (A) Restraint, listening and growth in the essentials of all sects
- (B) Election of monks as governors
- (C) Destruction of every non-Buddhist shrine
- (D) End of royal patronage

Answer: A - Restraint, listening and growth in the essentials of all sects **Explanation: The edict seeks dialogue and mutual understanding.**

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XII

Qualification: Royal exhortation does not prove conflict ended.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 30 - Personal Buddhism

Which inscription most directly describes Ashoka as a lay follower who became more zealous gradually?

- (A) The Sohagaura plaque
- (B) Minor Rock Edict I
- (C) The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman
- (D) Major Rock Edict XIII alone

Answer: B - Minor Rock Edict I **Explanation: Minor Rock Edict I gives a staged account of lay affiliation and effort.**

Named evidence: Minor Rock Edict I

Qualification: The wording varies across versions.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 31 - Bhabru

What is distinctive about the Bhabru/Bairat inscription?

- (A) It lists all Mauryan tax rates
- (B) It records the Seleucid marriage
- (C) Ashoka recommends specific Buddhist texts to monks, nuns and lay followers
- (D) It is written only in Greek

Answer: C - Ashoka recommends specific Buddhist texts to monks, nuns and lay followers Explanation: It is direct evidence of personal Buddhist textual preference.

Named evidence: Bhabru Minor Rock Edict

Qualification: It should not be treated as the content of all public dhamma edicts.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 32 - Dhamma machinery

Who were the principal special officers for Ashoka's dhamma programme?

- (A) Only Greek ambassadors
- (B) Harappan merchants
- (C) Shunga feudatories
- (D) Dhamma-mahamattas

Answer: D - Dhamma-mahamattas Explanation: They worked across social groups, sects and frontier communities.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict V

Qualification: Their effectiveness cannot be measured from the edict alone.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 33 - Audience

Who formed the largest practical audience for many edicts?

- (A) Subjects hearing the message through officials and oral recitation
- (B) Only Hellenistic kings
- (C) Only Buddhist monks at Pataliputra
- (D) Only literate royal scribes reading privately

Answer: A - Subjects hearing the message through officials and oral recitation Explanation: Low literacy and difficult placements made intermediaries essential.

Named evidence: Separate edicts; Rock Edict III; oral-reading instructions

Qualification: Reception varied by language, authority and local conditions.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 34 - Scripts

Which script-language pairing is correct?

- (A) Kandahar - Brahmi only
- (B) Shahbazgarhi - Kharoshthi and north-western Prakrit
- (C) Mansehra - Tamil-Brahmi only
- (D) Girnar - Greek only

Answer: B - Shahbazgarhi - Kharoshthi and north-western Prakrit Explanation: Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra use Kharoshthi.

Named evidence: Ashokan inscription corpus

Qualification: Script choice does not by itself identify ethnicity.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 35 - Major rock sites

Which pair consists of two Kalinga major/separate-edict sites in Odisha?

- (A) Maski and Brahmagiri
- (B) Mansehra and Shahbazgarhi
- (C) Dhauli and Jaugada
- (D) Kalsi and Girnar

Answer: C - Dhauli and Jaugada Explanation: Dhauli and Jaugada carry regionally adapted Kalinga texts.

Named evidence: Ashokan site list

Qualification: Exact administrative-centre identifications remain debated.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 36 - Pillars

Which site preserves an Ashokan pillar inscription commemorating the Buddha's birthplace and a tax concession?

- (A) Sogaura
- (B) Kanaganahalli
- (C) Sopara
- (D) Rummindei (Lumbini)

Answer: D - Rummindei (Lumbini) Explanation: The Rummindei inscription records the royal visit and fiscal privilege.

Named evidence: Rummindei pillar

Qualification: It is a local commemoration, not a general tax code.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 37 - Southern neighbours

Which group is presented in the edicts as southern neighbours rather than securely annexed provinces?

- (A) Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputras
- (B) Pataliputra, Kaushambi, Vaishali and Rajgir
- (C) Kandahar, Mansehra, Kalsi and Girnar
- (D) Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri

Answer: A - Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputras Explanation: Rock Edicts II/XIII distinguish these polities from the imperial domain.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edicts II and XIII

Qualification: Dhamma outreach is not territorial sovereignty.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 38 - Foreign horizon

What do the Hellenistic kings named in Rock Edict XIII prove most securely?

- (A) A Greek army stationed at Sanchi
- (B) Ashoka's awareness of and claimed moral outreach to a wider geopolitical world
- (C) Mauryan annexation of Egypt and Macedonia
- (D) Conversion certificates from all five courts

Answer: B - Ashoka's awareness of and claimed moral outreach to a wider geopolitical world Explanation: The names frame dhamma-vijaya beyond the subcontinent.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII

Qualification: The claim does not verify reception or conversion abroad.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 39 - Sarnath capital

Which feature belongs to the Sarnath Lion Capital?

- (A) A cave facade dedicated to Ajivikas
- (B) A seated portrait labelled Ranyo Ashoka
- (C) Four back-to-back lions above an animal-and-wheel abacus
- (D) A fluted shaft on a square Persian base

Answer: C - Four back-to-back lions above an animal-and-wheel abacus Explanation: The capital is a Mauryan sculptural and symbolic masterpiece.

Named evidence: ASI Sarnath; archaeological corpus

Qualification: The modern emblem is a later national adoption.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 40 - Sanchi layers

Which statement about Sanchi Stupa 1 is correct?

- (A) It began as an Ajivika cave
- (B) It was entirely Gupta
- (C) Its toranas were carved by Chandragupta
- (D) Its brick core is Ashokan, while major stone casing, railings and gateways are later

Answer: D - Its brick core is Ashokan, while major stone casing, railings and gateways are later Explanation: The floor relationship with the Ashokan pillar supports the Mauryan core.

Named evidence: Sanchi archaeology; UNESCO/ASI

Qualification: Visible fabric combines several dynasties.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 41 - Barabar

The Ashokan cave dedications at Barabar were made primarily to:

- (A) Ajivikas
- (B) Greek soldiers
- (C) Shaiva mathas
- (D) Roman traders

Answer: A - Ajivikas Explanation: The inscriptions name the Ajivika sect.

Named evidence: Barabar cave inscriptions

Qualification: Lomash Rishi lacks the same dedication but is contextually close.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 42 - Kumrahar

What is the safest description of the Kumrahar eighty-pillared remains?

- (A) A Harappan granary
- (B) A major Mauryan-associated hall whose exact function remains debated
- (C) A Gupta cave temple
- (D) A securely identified throne room named in an Ashokan edict

Answer: B - A major Mauryan-associated hall whose exact function remains debated Explanation: The pillars and structural traces establish scale, not an uncontested function.

Named evidence: Kumrahar excavation record

Qualification: Tourism labels can be more definite than archaeology.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 43 - Polish

Why is 'Mauryan polish' an unsafe sole dating criterion?

- (A) Every Ashokan pillar is unpolished
- (B) Only wooden objects were polished
- (C) Highly polished stone surfaces continued after the Mauryan period
- (D) Mauryan craftsmen never polished stone

Answer: C - Highly polished stone surfaces continued after the Mauryan period Explanation: Objects such as Didarganj and other figures have disputed dates.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh's art discussion

Qualification: Polish remains useful when combined with inscription, style and context.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 44 - Art interaction

Which formulation best captures Persian/Hellenistic influence on Mauryan art?

- (A) A purely Greek workforce proven by style
- (B) Exact copying of Persepolis
- (C) Complete isolation from western Asia
- (D) Selective borrowing and transformation within distinct Indian forms and meanings

Answer: D - Selective borrowing and transformation within distinct Indian forms and meanings Explanation: Shared motifs coexist with major formal and semantic differences.

Named evidence: Pillar comparisons; script/art contact

Qualification: Artist ethnicity cannot be inferred from motif alone.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 45 - Centralisation

Which is the most defensible model of the Mauryan state?

- (A) A strong but differentiated empire with regionally and functionally varied control
- (B) A purely symbolic realm without taxation or officers
- (C) Identical administration in every village
- (D) A modern unitary nation-state

Answer: A - A strong but differentiated empire with regionally and functionally varied control Explanation: Provinces and officers show capacity; communication and regional archaeology show variation.

Named evidence: Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate

Qualification: The balance may differ by reign and zone.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 46 - Communication

Why do inspection tours simultaneously indicate capacity and limitation?

- (A) They eliminated provincial governors
- (B) They show active supervision but also dependence on slow movement and intermediaries
- (C) They prove instant telecommunication
- (D) They were only religious pilgrimages

Answer: B - They show active supervision but also dependence on slow movement and intermediaries

Explanation: Five- and three-year tours connected centre and field.

Named evidence: Rock Edict III and Separate Rock Edict I

Qualification: Frequency does not reveal complete route coverage.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 47 - Memory

What do the Kanaganahalli reliefs most directly reveal?

- (A) Ashoka's verified physical appearance
- (B) The text of the Seleucus treaty
- (C) The post-Mauryan Buddhist iconic memory of Ashoka
- (D) The original Sarnath wheel

Answer: C - The post-Mauryan Buddhist iconic memory of Ashoka
Explanation: Labelled reliefs show how later Buddhist communities represented him.

Named evidence: Kanaganahalli excavations and labels

Qualification: They were carved centuries after Ashoka.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Hard MCQ 48 - Method

Which answer sentence best follows evidence discipline?

- (A) Megasthenes accurately described all India
- (B) Ashoka became completely nonviolent and abolished the state
- (C) The Arthashastra proves every Mauryan monopoly operated
- (D) Rock Edict XIII proclaims remorse and dhamma-vijaya, but its warning to forest peoples shows retained coercive authority

Answer: D - Rock Edict XIII proclaims remorse and dhamma-vijaya, but its warning to forest peoples shows retained coercive authority
Explanation: The sentence names evidence, significance and qualification.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII

Qualification: No single source exhausts the empire.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 49 - Arthashastra trap

Which correction is necessary when using the Arthashastra?

- (A) Call it a theoretical/redacted text and corroborate Mauryan claims
- (B) Use it instead of inscriptions
- (C) Treat every prescription as an executed imperial order
- (D) Date it only from Chandragupta's court without debate

Answer: A - Call it a theoretical/redacted text and corroborate Mauryan claims Explanation: The final text describes a potential monarchy, not a transparent Mauryan manual.

Named evidence: Arthashastra dating debate

Qualification: Some concepts may preserve earlier traditions.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 50 - Map trap

What is wrong with equating the edict map with uniform direct administration?

- (A) All edicts were moved to Delhi
- (B) Communication claims and actual control can vary by region
- (C) Edicts are not ancient
- (D) Brahmi was unreadable in Ashoka's time

Answer: B - Communication claims and actual control can vary by region Explanation: Find-spots must be combined with local archaeology and political context.

Named evidence: Regional edict distribution

Qualification: Absence and presence both require preservation caution.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 51 - Founder trap

Who founded the Mauryan dynasty?

- (A) Bindusara
- (B) Pushyamitra Shunga
- (C) Chandragupta Maurya
- (D) Ashoka

Answer: C - Chandragupta Maurya Explanation: Chandragupta overthrew the Nandas and created Mauryan power.

Named evidence: Dynastic traditions and classical notices

Qualification: Exact date and early sequence vary.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 52 - Dhamma trap

Which correction best addresses 'dhamma was the Mauryan state religion'?

- (A) Every subject was compelled to become a monk
- (B) Ashoka had no relation to Buddhism
- (C) Dhamma meant only tax collection
- (D) Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but public dhamma was a broader plural social ethic

Answer: D - Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but public dhamma was a broader plural social ethic

Explanation: Minor edicts and Rock Edict XII must be read together.

Named evidence: MRE I/Bhabru; RE XII; Barabar gifts

Qualification: Dhamma retained Buddhist roots and paternal authority.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 53 - Pacifism trap

Which evidence blocks the claim that Ashoka abolished all coercion?

- (A) Forest warning and continued death penalty
- (B) The Parkham yaksha
- (C) The Sarnath abacus alone
- (D) The Mahavamsa mission list alone

Answer: A - Forest warning and continued death penalty **Explanation: Rock Edict XIII and Pillar Edict IV retain punishment.**

Named evidence: RE XIII; PE IV

Qualification: Ashoka's anti-war reflection remains historically significant.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 54 - Sanchi trap

Which element of the Great Stupa is Mauryan?

- (A) The Gupta Buddha images
- (B) The original brick core
- (C) All visible stone railings
- (D) The carved toranas in their present form

Answer: B - The original brick core **Explanation: The monumental site accumulated layers across dynasties.**

Named evidence: Sanchi archaeology and ASI/UNESCO

Qualification: Exact reconstructions of the first phase are limited.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 55 - Cave trap

The Barabar cave inscriptions are crucial because they show:

- (A) An exclusive Buddhist state
- (B) A Gupta land grant
- (C) Ashokan patronage of Ajivikas and early rock-cut architecture
- (D) A Greek naval base

Answer: C - Ashokan patronage of Ajivikas and early rock-cut architecture Explanation: The dedication and technology are both historically significant.

Named evidence: Barabar inscriptions

Qualification: Not every nearby cave has the same inscription.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 56 - Polish trap

A polished stone figure without stratified context should be dated by:

- (A) Polish alone
- (B) Its museum label alone
- (C) Modern popularity
- (D) Combining inscription, style, material technology and context

Answer: D - Combining inscription, style, material technology and context Explanation: Mauryan-style polish continued later.

Named evidence: Didarganj/Lohanipur/Parkham debates

Qualification: Different indicators may conflict.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 57 - Megasthenes trap

Which Megasthenes statement is demonstrably unsafe?

- (A) India had no slaves
- (B) He visited a Mauryan court
- (C) India had elephants
- (D) Pataliputra used much wood

Answer: A - India had no slaves Explanation: Ashokan and Indian textual evidence names slaves/servants.

Named evidence: RE IX/XI and other texts

Qualification: Forms of dependence varied.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 58 - Officer trap

Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta should be remembered as:

- (A) Foreign kings
- (B) District-level officers in the 2025 official key, with distinct functions
- (C) Three Buddhist sects
- (D) One identical village office

Answer: B - District-level officers in the 2025 official key, with distinct functions Explanation: The exam fact and functional caveat must coexist.

Named evidence: UPSC 2025 Q19; RE III

Qualification: Ancient levels do not map perfectly onto modern districts.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 59 - Kalinga trap

What happened territorially after Ashoka's remorse?

- (A) The Mauryan capital moved to Dhauri
- (B) The army was transferred to Seleucus
- (C) Kalinga remained incorporated while policy language and governance changed
- (D) Kalinga was immediately restored as an independent kingdom

Answer: C - Kalinga remained incorporated while policy language and governance changed Explanation: Separate edicts address post-conquest administration.

Named evidence: RE XIII; Separate Kalinga Edicts

Qualification: Degree of pacification is uncertain.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

Remedial MCQ 60 - Mission trap

How should the Mahinda-Sanghamitta mission be presented?

- (A) As a verbatim Ashokan edict
- (B) As a Hellenistic treaty clause
- (C) As an event denied by all Buddhist sources
- (D) As a later Sri Lankan chronicle tradition with possible contextual corroboration

Answer: D - As a later Sri Lankan chronicle tradition with possible contextual corroboration Explanation: The tradition is historically important but not contemporary inscriptional proof.

Named evidence: Mahavamsa/Dipavamsa; Sanchi relic context

Qualification: The full mission list cannot be independently verified.

Elimination logic: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with uniformly realised Mauryan practice.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2019 Q8: Ranyo Ashoka portrait

Question: In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (A) Kanganahalli
- (B) Sanchi
- (C) Shahbazgarhi
- (D) Sohgaure

Answer/status: A - Kanganahalli

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official question paper controls wording; the official key is not held in the repository.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Kanganahalli	Raya/Ranyo Asoko label with royal reliefs	Correct identification	Reliefs are 2nd-3rd century CE memories, not lifetime portraits
Sanchi	Later reliefs interpreted as Ashoka scenes	Important memory of Ashoka	The named inscription in this PYQ is not Sanchi
Shahbazgarhi	Kharoshthi Major Rock Edicts	Ashokan epigraphy	Not a portrait-relief site
Sohgaure	Debated early-historic famine/storehouse plaque	Administrative-history evidence	Not a portrait-relief inscription

Solved analysis

- The Kanganahalli stupa excavations produced limestone reliefs labelled 'Raya Asoko' and showing a king with a queen and attendants.
- The sculptures were made centuries after Ashoka; they reveal his early iconic memory in Buddhist art rather than his actual appearance.
- Elimination works by separating an art-memory site from rock-edict and administrative-inscription sites.

Why this earns marks: It gives the key, identifies the labelled artefact, distinguishes representation from eyewitness portraiture, and eliminates each distractor by evidence class.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2020 Q30: sectarian concord inscription

Question: Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely'?

- (A) Ashoka
- (B) Samudragupta
- (C) Harshavardhana
- (D) Krishnadeva Raya

Answer/status: A - Ashoka

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local 2020 official paper; repository routing records no local official key.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Named source	Major Rock Edict XII	Restraint in praising one's sect and condemning others	Translation wording varies
Positive demand	Growth in essentials and listening to other sects	Concord exceeds passive toleration	Royal exhortation is not proof of harmony
Ashoka's position	Honours all sects while personally Buddhist	Separates public policy from personal faith	Paternal royal authority remains
Distractors	Prashasti/court traditions of later rulers	Different genres and periods	Religious patronage alone does not identify the quotation

Solved analysis

- The quotation condenses Ashoka's Major Rock Edict XII.
- The decisive phrase is not generic tolerance but the injury caused to one's own sect by excessive self-praise and denunciation of others.
- A high-quality explanation adds that Ashoka sought dialogue and growth in the essentials of all sects, not a modern secular state.

Why this earns marks: It anchors the answer to a named edict and explains the ethical-political content instead of relying on ruler recognition alone.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q60: Arthashastra and slavery

Question: According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, consider: (1) a person could be a slave as a result of judicial punishment; (2) if a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free; (3) such a son fathered by the master had the legal status of the master's son. Which are correct?

- (A) 1 and 2 only
- (B) 2 and 3 only
- (C) 1 and 3 only
- (D) 1, 2 and 3

Answer/status: B - 2 and 3 only

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held. The key follows the text-based legal distinction.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Judicial punishment wording	Not accepted in the keyed text interpretation	Translations and slavery categories require care
Statement 2	Freedom of the mother after bearing master's son	Correct Arthashastra provision	Normative law, not social census
Statement 3	Status of the son	Correct legal provision	Does not establish frequency or empire-wide implementation
Historical use	Arthashastra slavery rules	Evidence for legal-political thought	Not transparent Mauryan practice

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 form a connected legal rule on manumission and filial status.
- The question asks 'according to the Arthashastra'; it does not ask what Ashoka's administration practised.
- The package therefore solves the objective demand while preserving the composition/redaction and prescription caveat.

Why this earns marks: It demonstrates demand fidelity: text-specific answer first, then source criticism without allowing the caveat to obscure the key.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q91: Major Rock Edict sites

Question: Consider the pairs: Dhauli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-Karnataka. How many are correctly matched?

- (A) Only one pair
- (B) Only two pairs
- (C) Only three pairs
- (D) All four pairs

Answer/status: B - Only two pairs

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Dhuli	Odisha	Correct; Separate Kalinga Edicts replace part of standard set	Modern district references can change
Erragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Correct; Major and minor rock-edict context	Spelling Yerragudi/Erragudi varies
Jaugada	Odisha, not Madhya Pradesh	Incorrect pair	Kalinga regional context
Kalsi	Uttarakhand, not Karnataka	Incorrect pair	North Indian Himalayan-foothill route

Solved analysis

- Only Dhuli-Odisha and Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh are correct.
- A map-first method prevents phonetic or vague-regional guessing.
- Dhuli and Jaugada should be mentally paired as Kalinga sites; Kalsi belongs to Uttarakhand.

Why this earns marks: It supplies exact state corrections and links geography to inscription category, creating durable elimination memory.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2025 Q19: Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta

Question: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at which level?

- (A) Village-level administration
- (B) District-level administration
- (C) Provincial administration
- (D) Central administration

Answer/status: B - District-level administration

Verification: OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Pradeshika	Rock Edict III tour context	District-level field officer	Exact rank/function not identical to modern district magistrate
Rajuka	Land-measurement hypothesis; justice/welfare/dhamma	High field responsibility	Etymology is not a complete job description
Yukta	Directed duties and tours	Subordinate/executive accounting-administrative role	Context changes
Collective context	Five-year tours for dhamma and other purposes	District-level administration	No single modern hierarchy should be forced

Solved analysis

- The official answer is district-level administration.
- Rock Edict III groups the three for quinquennial tours, while other inscriptions expand rajuka duties.
- The examination fact should be retained without pretending that the three offices were identical.

Why this earns marks: It uses the official local key, names the edict context, and protects against over-modernising ancient titles.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2023 Q42: stupa origin and function

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- (A) Only one
- (B) Only two
- (C) All three
- (D) None

Answer/status: B - Only two

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included because Ashokan stupa patronage is a Topic 14 subtheme.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Funerary mound tradition predates/exceeds Buddhism	Incorrect	Buddhism transformed and popularised the form
Statement 2	Relic enshrinement	Correct for many Buddhist stupas	Not every stupa necessarily held relics
Statement 3	Votive and commemorative roles	Correct	Functions changed by site and period
Mauryan link	Sanchi brick core; Nigali Sagar enlargement	Ashoka's major patronage phase	Later visible additions must be dated separately

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 are correct; the stupa form was not exclusively Buddhist in origin.
- Ashoka's significance lies in patronage, enlargement, commemoration and popularisation, not invention of the mound.
- Sanchi's Mauryan brick core and later gateways provide the crucial chronology trap.

Why this earns marks: It answers the objective demand and ties the result to a precise Mauryan architectural chronology.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Verified adjacent Mains PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q1: rock-cut architecture

Question: Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss with reference to rock-cut architecture. (10 marks, 150 words)

Answer/status: Model answer

Verification: VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Barabar and Mauryan beginnings.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Mauryan beginning	Barabar caves; Ashokan Ajivika dedications	Imperial patronage, ascetic space and rock technology	Lomash Rishi itself has no Ashokan dedication
Formal idea	Hut/wooden forms translated into rock	Tradition reworked through durable medium	Chronology and patronage vary
Later expansion	Buddhist chaitya-vihara complexes such as Bhaja/Ajanta	Ritual movement, congregational worship and monastic residence	Later evidence should not be backdated
Plural traditions	Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical caves	Philosophy and patronage shaped form and iconography	Material, labour and politics also matter

Solved analysis

- **THESIS:** Rock-cut architecture materialised Indian traditions of renunciation, sacred presence, congregation and patronage, while craftsmen transformed earlier wooden forms into enduring stone.
- **MODEL:** The Mauryan Barabar caves provide the earliest surviving imperial stage: Ashoka's inscriptions dedicate highly polished caves to Ajivikas, linking royal patronage with ascetic withdrawal. The Lomash Rishi facade imitates a timber-and-thatch entrance, showing translation rather than mere copying. Later Buddhist chaityas organised worship around a stupa and circumambulation, while viharas institutionalised monastic residence; Jain and Brahmanical caves adapted the medium to their own sacred narratives and icons. Yet philosophy alone did not cut rock: court or mercantile patronage, quarrying skill, labour and route-linked monastic economies made these monuments possible. Thus ideas supplied purpose and symbolism, while technology and institutions shaped the realised form.
- **VERDICT:** Rock-cut architecture is evidence of interaction among doctrine, ritual, patronage, material technology and landscape.

Why this earns marks: It directly discusses the role of philosophy/tradition, uses Barabar and later comparators, adds material causation, and avoids calling every early cave Buddhist.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Original solved 10-marker 1 - Sources of Mauryan history

Question: Why must the Mauryan Empire be reconstructed through source criticism rather than by combining all available texts at face value? (150 words)

Demand and thesis: Mauryan reconstruction is unusually rich but methodologically difficult because inscriptions, archaeology, classical fragments, theoretical texts and later traditions answer different questions.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Edicts	Rock Edicts VI, XII, XIII; Pillar Edict IV	Direct royal voice on duty, concord, Kalinga and justice	Intent is clearer than implementation
Archaeology	Kumrahar, Bulandibagh, Sanchi and Barabar	Material institutions and technology	Function/identity may be debated
Megasthenes	Indica through Strabo/Arrian	Court and Pataliputra observations	Double filter and errors
Arthashastra	Redacted statecraft treatise	Political-economic ideas	Not a Mauryan manual

Model answer

Mauryan history cannot be written by merging unlike archives. Ashoka's edicts are contemporary and securely reveal his public voice: Rock Edict XIII records Kalinga remorse, Rock Edict XII sectarian concord and Pillar Edict IV judicial restraint. Yet they are royal proclamations and seldom describe routine administration.

Archaeology at Bulandibagh and Kumrahar partly supports a wooden fortified Pataliputra and a large pillared hall, but the hall's exact function remains disputed. Megasthenes is valuable for the court and city, yet his lost Indica survives through later writers and contains errors such as denying slavery. The Arthashastra offers sophisticated statecraft prescriptions, but its composition/redaction and non-descriptive genre prevent treating it as Chandragupta's constitution. Buddhist, Jain and Puranic texts preserve memory but are later and sectarian.

Therefore, claims should be accepted only at the level supported by genre, date and corroboration.

Why this earns marks: The answer names four source classes, supplies precise examples, states what each proves, and ends with a method rather than a source list.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 10-marker 2 - Chandragupta and imperial foundation

Question: Assess Chandragupta Maurya's role in creating the Mauryan Empire. (150 words)

Demand and thesis: Chandragupta converted the inherited Magadhan-Nanda fiscal-military base and north-western political fluidity into a durable imperial framework through conquest and diplomacy.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Foundation	Nanda-overthrow traditions	Control of Magadha and Pataliputra	Narrative details vary
North-west	Justin/Plutarch notices	Large conquest remembered	Army figures and 'India' are imprecise
Diplomacy	Seleucus settlement and 500 elephants	Stabilised frontier and exchanged military assets	Date/marriage clauses uncertain
West/south	Junagadh inscription; Mamulanar/Jain traditions	Saurashtra and possible trans-Vindhyan reach	Later/poetic evidence

Model answer

Chandragupta was the principal architect of Mauryan power, not merely Ashoka's predecessor. He overthrew the Nandas and secured Magadha's agrarian-revenue base, Pataliputra and inherited military resources. Graeco-Roman writers remember Sandrocottus as a conqueror of great scale, although their 600,000 figure and use of 'India' are not precise statistics.

His conflict and treaty with Seleucus, conventionally placed around 305-301 BCE, demonstrate strategic diplomacy: the tradition records territorial concessions in the north-west and 500 elephants supplied to Seleucus, while the alleged marriage alliance remains uncertain. Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription attributes the beginning of the Sudarshana reservoir to Chandragupta's governor Pushyagupta, supporting western administration. Tamil and Jain traditions suggest southern links but are too late or poetic to map direct rule.

Thus Chandragupta created the core, frontier settlement and governing scale that Bindusara preserved and Ashoka later articulated inscriptionally.

Why this earns marks: It answers role rather than biography, uses four named evidence units, and qualifies every indirect tradition.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 10-marker 3 - Dhamma and Buddhism

Question: Ashoka's dhamma was not simply Buddhism. Explain. (150 words)

Demand and thesis: Ashoka's public dhamma was an imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, while his personal Buddhist adherence had a separate and explicit inscriptional record.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Personal Buddhism	Minor Rock Edict I; Bhabru; Rummindei	Lay adherence, Buddhist texts and pilgrimage	Special inscriptions
Public conduct	Rock Edicts IX and XI	Parents, elders, servants, generosity and non-killing	Maintains hierarchy
Concord	Rock Edicts VII and XII	Honour/listen to all sects	Not modern secularism
Plural patronage	Barabar caves for Ajivikas	State not exclusively Buddhist	Royal paternalism remains

Model answer

Ashoka's Buddhism and dhamma overlap but are not identical. Minor Rock Edict I calls him a lay follower who gradually became more zealous; the Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts, and Rummindei records his Lumbini pilgrimage. These establish personal faith.

The major public edicts, however, define dhamma through social conduct: respect for parents and elders, courtesy to slaves and servants, generosity to Brahmanas and shramanas, self-control and reduced injury to living beings. Rock Edict XII asks sects to restrain self-praise, listen to others and promote concord. Such an ethic addresses a plural empire and omits central Buddhist teachings such as the Four Noble Truths and nirvana. Ashoka also donated Barabar caves to Ajivikas.

Dhamma was therefore a Buddhist-inflected ethical-political programme for imperial society, not compulsory conversion or a Buddhist state religion.

Why this earns marks: The answer distinguishes faith, doctrine, public policy and patronage with four named inscriptions and a clear verdict.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 15-marker 1 - Mauryan administration

Question: Examine the structure and working of Mauryan administration with reference to the strengths and limits of the evidence. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: The Mauryan state had a substantial multi-tiered hierarchy and information network, but its exact organisation and reach must be reconstructed mainly from Ashokan inscriptions and regionally bounded corroboration.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Centre	King, parishad and Rock Edict VI reporters	Command and information	Royal ideal
Province	Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali, Suvarnagiri; kumaras	Regional supervision	Reconstructed scheme
District	Pradeshika, rajuka, yukta	Tours, justice and field administration	Ranks/functions overlap
Special cadres	Mahamattas, pativedakas, pulisani	Portfolio and reporting differentiation	Titles do not give staff depth
Municipal/military	Megasthenes' six committees	Possible Pataliputra arrangements	Fragmentary and suspiciously symmetrical

Model answer

Mauryan administration was organised around the king, consultative bodies, provincial centres and mobile field officers. Rock Edict VI presents Ashoka as continuously accessible to pativedakas and requires disputes in the parishad to reach him immediately. This indicates a strong ideal of personal command, while also revealing dependence on reporters.

The empire appears to have had major provincial centres at Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri, often under kumaras or aryaputras. The later Junagadh inscription names Pushyagupta as Chandragupta's governor in Saurashtra. At district level, Rock Edict III groups pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas for five-year tours; the 2025 official UPSC key identifies them as district officers. Rajukas also received judicial and welfare duties in Pillar Edict IV.

Specialised mahamattas included frontier, women's-affairs and dhamma cadres. Separate Rock Edict I ordered scrutiny of arbitrary imprisonment in Kalinga, showing both corrective capacity and official misconduct. Megasthenes' six municipal and military committees may reflect Pataliputra, but the lost Indica's fragmentary transmission and schematic symmetry require caution. Arthashastra offices such as samaharta and sannidhata are valuable theoretical comparators, not automatically attested Mauryan posts.

Thus the state was administratively ambitious and layered, but uneven field reach, communication delays and source genre prevent describing it as a modern uniform bureaucracy.

Why this earns marks: It covers centre, province, district, special officers, justice and city/military claims; every institutional claim carries a named source and limitation.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 15-marker 2 - Kalinga and post-war policy

Question: Analyse how the Kalinga war altered Ashoka's conception and practice of kingship. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: Kalinga did not end Mauryan coercion; it transformed Ashoka's public kingship by making suffering, restraint, welfare and dhamma-vijaya central to imperial legitimacy.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Violence	Major Rock Edict XIII casualty/deportation claim	Royal recognition of conquest's social cost	Figures unverified
Moral turn	First-person remorse	Confessional political language	Also self-fashioning
Administration	Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II	Fairness, trust and paternalism	Implementation unknown
New conquest	Dhamma-vijaya	Moral influence preferred to fresh annexation	Not foreign sovereignty
Coercive remainder	Forest warning; Pillar Edict IV	Punishment and death penalty retained	Does not negate ethical innovation

Model answer

Major Rock Edict XIII presents Kalinga as a decisive reflection on kingship. Ashoka records 150,000 deported, 100,000 killed and many more dead; these are royal inscriptional claims rather than audited totals. More important is his expansion of suffering beyond combatants to relatives, householders, Brahmanas, shramanas, slaves and servants. Victory is therefore judged by its dispersed human cost.

The policy response had three dimensions. First, Ashoka preferred dhamma-vijaya-moral influence and restraint-over fresh territorial conquest and urged successors to avoid harsh warfare. Second, the Separate Kalinga Edicts addressed officials at Tosali and Samapa, demanded confidence-building and fair justice, and expressed the paternal formula that all people were his children. Third, the communication apparatus expanded through tours, oral readings and dhamma-mahamattas.

Yet Kalinga did not produce absolute pacifism. The territory remained annexed; Rock Edict XIII warned forest peoples that the repentant king retained power to punish, and Pillar Edict IV presupposed capital punishment. Nor can the war be reduced to a sudden conversion, because Minor Rock Edict I indicates gradual Buddhist commitment.

Kalinga thus transformed the language, ethical burden and declared priorities of rule while preserving the coercive foundations of empire.

Why this earns marks: It analyses change in ideas, administration and coercion, uses three edict groups, and avoids both cynical strategy-only and total-pacifism readings.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 15-marker 3 - Art as imperial communication

Question: Discuss Mauryan art and architecture as instruments of political communication as well as products of religious and craft traditions. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: Mauryan monumental art made imperial power visible, but its forms also drew on religious symbolism, artisan skill, transregional contact and non-royal patronage.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Pillars	Sarnath, Sanchi, Vaishali and edict pillars	Royal presence and dhamma text	Not all pillars inscribed
Stupas	Sanchi brick core; Nigali Sagar	Buddhist commemoration and patronage	Later additions distinct
Caves	Barabar Ajivika donations	Rock technology and plural patronage	Not all Buddhist
Capital	Kumrahar hall and Bulandibagh palisade	Court/urban capacity	Function/date debated
Popular art	Terracottas, ring stones and Parkham yaksha	Urban belief and corporate donors	Dating/context uneven

Model answer

Mauryan art communicated both imperial power and a wider religious-social world. Ashokan pillars combined long polished shafts, lotus-abacus-animal capitals and inscriptions. At Sarnath, four lions and wheels carried overlapping royal and Buddhist meanings; by placing dhamma proclamations on monumental stone, Ashoka converted artistic form into a durable political voice.

Buddhist patronage is visible in Sanchi's Ashokan brick stupa core and the Nigali Sagar record of enlarging Kanakamuni's stupa. However, Sanchi's stone casing and toranas are later and must not be credited to Ashoka. Barabar cave inscriptions dedicate highly polished rock-cut spaces to Ajivikas, demonstrating plural patronage and the translation of wooden architectural forms into rock. Kumrahar's pillared hall and Bulandibagh's timber fortification suggest the scale of Pataliputra, though the hall's function remains debated.

Court art did not exhaust the period. Parkham's inscribed Manibhadra yaksha, terracottas and ring stones reveal corporate and popular patronage. Persian/Hellenistic contacts influenced motifs and techniques, but smooth unbased shafts, independent animal capitals and ethical inscriptions created distinct forms.

Mauryan art was therefore an imperial communication system embedded in religious plurality, workshop networks and early-historic urban culture.

Why this earns marks: It covers pillars, stupas, caves, capital and popular art, dates layers, names inscriptions/sites, and balances influence with transformation.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 20-marker 1 - Centralised or differentiated empire

Question: Was the Mauryan Empire a highly centralised state? Critically evaluate with inscriptional and archaeological evidence. (350 words)

Demand and thesis: The Mauryan Empire possessed strong central institutions and strategic control, but its governance was differentiated by function, region, communication distance and inherited local structures.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Central capacity	King, parishad, provinces, mahamattas and district officers	Hierarchy and delegation	Archive concentrated under Ashoka
Information/coercion	RE VI reporters; inspections; army and forest warning	Command, surveillance and deterrence	Latency and compliance problems
Regional adaptation	Greek/Aramaic versions and Kharoshthi north-west	Local official initiative	Not proof of autonomy in every sphere
Archaeological variation	Northern NBPW/art package versus southern Deccan	Uneven material integration	Excavation remains incomplete
Political model	Thapar, Fussman and Sugandhi	Metropolitan/core/periphery and communication limits	Models are interpretive

Model answer

The Mauryan Empire was centralised in aspiration and in selected strategic functions, but not a uniformly administered territorial machine. A centralised reading rests on unprecedented scale, Pataliputra, royal princes at provincial centres, numerous mahamattas, district officers, fiscal extraction and a large army. Rock Edict VI orders pativedakas to report affairs to Ashoka at any time; Rock Edict III sends pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas on quinquennial tours. Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri linked major corridors to the court, while Separate Rock Edict I shows provincial inspection and judicial correction.

Yet the same evidence discloses limits. Five-year tours and repeated orders were necessary because information moved slowly and officials could imprison or torture arbitrarily. Megasthenes' municipal and military committees may illuminate Pataliputra, but his lost work is filtered and cannot be generalised to all India. The Arthashastra's all-controlling state is a theoretical and redacted model, not a Mauryan administrative manual.

Regional evidence strengthens the differentiated interpretation. Greek and Aramaic inscriptions in the north-west are adaptations rather than literal translations, implying local linguistic competence and discretion. Major rock edicts cluster toward borders, pillar edicts in north India and minor edicts strongly in the Andhra-Karnataka zone. Namita Sugandhi notes that southern regions do not reproduce the northern NBPW, coin and court-art package; an edict therefore marks contact and a claim to authority more securely than uniform direct rule.

Historiographically, Thapar moved from a highly centralised formulation to a metropolitan-core-periphery model, while Fussman emphasised communication limits. These corrections should not erase capacity: governors, waterworks such as Sudarshana, judicial edicts, multilingual communication and deterrence were real.

The best verdict is functionally graded: appointments, imperial ideology and strategic routes were relatively centralised; taxation, local justice, everyday production and frontier control depended more heavily on provincial officers, local intermediaries and negotiated variation.

Why this earns marks: It defines centralisation by function, uses more than eight named evidence units, engages three interpretations, and reaches a graded rather than binary verdict.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 20-marker 2 - Power and piety under Ashoka

Question: Ashoka's kingship combined power and piety rather than replacing one with the other. Discuss. (350 words)

Demand and thesis: Ashoka moralised imperial power through dhamma, welfare and restraint, but his programme remained authoritative, administrative and coercively backed.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Piety	MRE I, Bhabru, Rummindei and Nigali Sagar	Personal Buddhism and pilgrimage/patronage	Not equal to public policy
Public ethic	RE IX, XI and XII	Social duty and concord	Paternal, not egalitarian
Power	RE VI reporting; mahamattas; tours	Administrative mobilisation	Implementation variable
Kalinga	RE XIII and Separate Kalinga Edicts	Remorse plus post-conquest reform	Kalinga retained
Coercion	Forest warning; PE IV death penalty	Deterrence and punishment	Does not nullify ethical change

Model answer

Ashoka did not exchange empire for renunciation; he attempted to redefine how imperial power should be justified and exercised. His personal piety is explicit: Minor Rock Edict I presents gradual commitment as a Buddhist lay follower, the Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts, Rummindei records a Lumbini pilgrimage and Nigali Sagar the enlargement of a stupa. Nevertheless, the public dhamma of the major edicts was broader than Buddhism.

Rock Edicts IX and XI translate morality into household and social duties-respect for parents and elders, courtesy to slaves and servants, generosity to Brahmanas and shramanas, and reduced injury. Rock Edict XII seeks restraint, listening and concord among sects. These ethical claims served a plural empire and created a new public language of rulership.

The programme was also an exercise of power. Dhamma-mahamattas entered multiple social domains; pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas toured districts; Rock Edict VI demanded reports at all times; inscriptions and oral readings carried the king's voice across routes and frontiers. Welfare measures-trees, wells, medicine and prisoner release claims-made paternal care part of legitimacy.

Kalinga reveals the fusion most clearly. Rock Edict XIII condemns the dispersed suffering of conquest and elevates dhamma-vijaya, while the Separate Kalinga Edicts order fairer administration and confidence-building. Yet Kalinga remained annexed. The same Rock Edict XIII warns forest peoples of punitive power, and Pillar Edict IV retains capital punishment with a three-day respite.

Ashoka's piety therefore constrained, redirected and legitimised power; it did not dissolve hierarchy, administration or coercion. His historical originality lies precisely in making moral self-scrutiny an imperial proclamation while retaining the machinery capable of enforcing rule.

Why this earns marks: It integrates personal faith, public ethics, administration, welfare, Kalinga and coercion; named inscriptions support every claim and the conclusion resolves the apparent contradiction.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.

Original solved 20-marker 3 - Economy and state control

Question: Critically examine the extent of Mauryan state control over the economy. (350 words)

Demand and thesis: The Mauryan state could intervene powerfully in land revenue, strategic resources, markets and infrastructure, but claims of a total command economy depend too heavily on the theoretical Arthashastra.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Fiscal base	Bhaga/bali and Rummindei concession	Agrarian extraction and local modification	Rates varied
Infrastructure	Sudarshana reservoir via Junagadh inscription	Provincial water management	Retrospective evidence
Urban regulation	Megasthenes' Pataliputra committees	Weights, trade and market tax	City-specific/fragmentary
Material economy	Coins, crafts and towns at Taxila, Mathura, Bhita and Ujjayini	Growth and specialisation	State causation not automatic
Maximal prescription	Arthashastra departments/monopolies	Potential high-capacity model	Post-Mauryan/redacted and normative

Model answer

Mauryan rule rested on a substantial agrarian and urban fiscal base, but the extent of direct state control must be graded. Land revenue was central: Indian norms commonly mention a one-sixth share, while the Rummindei pillar exempts Lumbini from bali and reduces bhaga to one-eighth. The concession proves both fiscal authority and local variation; it does not establish a uniform empire-wide rate.

The later Junagadh inscription associates Chandragupta's governor Pushyagupta and Ashoka's official Tushaspha with the Sudarshana reservoir, showing provincial investment in strategic water infrastructure. Megasthenes' Pataliputra account describes committees concerned with weights, trade, public sale and market taxes. These fragments suggest urban regulation, but his city-specific, filtered account cannot be projected across the empire.

Archaeology shows a broader economy with many actors. Taxila's shell workshop and urban drains, Mathura's metal and bead production, Bhita's nigama seal, Ujjayini's coins and ring wells, ports such as Sopara, and widespread punch-marked coins indicate crafts, corporate activity, routes and monetisation. The state may have secured corridors and collected dues, but merchants, artisans, cultivators and local elites remained indispensable.

The strongest total-control claims come from the Arthashastra's departments, monopolies, settlement schemes and espionage. Current scholarship treats the extant work as a theoretical, redacted and largely post-Mauryan text; it describes a potential monarchy, not an audited Mauryan economy. Sharma's state-control model is therefore a hypothesis to test, not a fact to reproduce.

The Mauryan economy was neither laissez-faire nor fully commanded. The state exercised selective high capacity in revenue, strategic works, markets and routes, while actual intervention varied by region and depended on non-state producers and intermediaries.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates degree, uses inscriptional, classical, archaeological and textual evidence, names multiple sites, and explicitly resolves the prescription-versus-practice problem.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named inscriptions, sites, texts, officials or artefacts in proportion to the demand; each major claim includes significance and qualification.